Our preparation was ideal, impeccably planned by Cricket South Africa, and we played no fewer than 21 one-day internationals in the five months leading up to the World Cup, trialling various combinations and plans. We won 14 of these games, with two no-results, and began to feel we could beat anyone on our day.

The squad looked strong: Hashim Amla, Quinton de Kock, Faf du Plessis, JP Duminy, Rilee Rossouw, Farhaan Behardien, David Miller and I were the batsmen; Dale Steyn, Morné Morkel, Vernon Philander, Kyle Abbott and Wayne Parnell were the pace bowlers; Imran Tahir and Aaron Phangiso were the spinners.

I was becoming nervous and excited as, in January 2015, we completed our preparations by winning four of five ODIs against the West Indies. It was Russell Domingo who kept us calm.

'It's just another tournament, AB,' our coach said, over and over again. 'We must focus on the basics and not try anything special. We'll give everything, of course, but let's not get too intense or stressed. It's a World Cup and it's not going to change our lives. Whatever happens, I will go fishing afterwards.'

Russell was choosing his words carefully and intelligently, deliberately aiming to lift the burden of pressure and expectation from the players, helping us relax. I like, respect and admire him as a good man. He is not the type of coach who will scream and shout for the sake of looking tough, but his approach should never be misinterpreted as soft. Instead, in his own way, he is able to draw the best out of the people around him.

I felt we combined well as coach and captain. We would address the squad before almost every training session and before every match, and Russell would generally speak first, addressing technical issues such as plans for opposing batsmen, calmly running through the basic mechanics of what we needed to do, and then my task would be to engage the other side of the brain, motivating the players by stirring their emotions.

My theme remained consistent before and during the Cricket World